

Graphics Systems

Computer Graphics
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Today

- **Image formation**
 - Three elements
- **Graphics systems**
 - Physical approach
 - Pipeline approach
- **Raster pipeline**
 - Vertex shader
 - Primitive assembler, clipper
 - Rasterizer
 - Fragment shader
 - Frame buffers

Image Formation

- **Geometry of image formation**

- determines where the projection of a point will be located in the image plane (or the sensor plane)

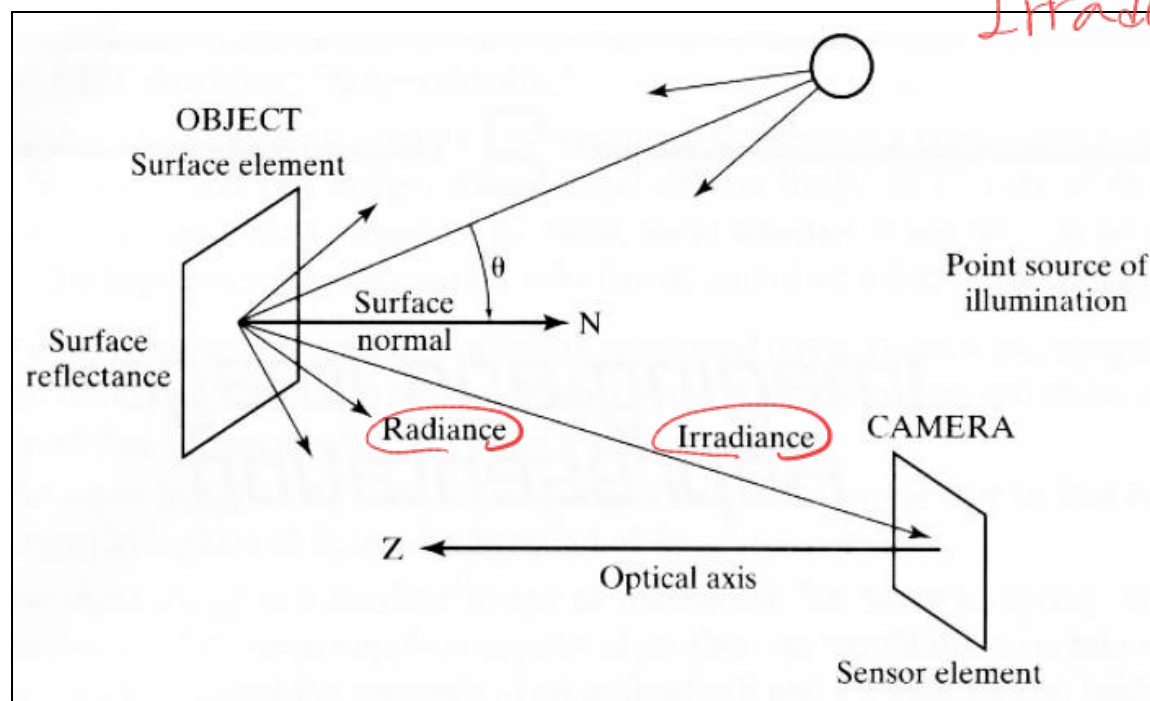
- **Physics of light**

- interaction of lights with geometric surfaces
- determines the brightness of a point in the image plane (or the sensor) as a function of illumination and surface properties
- **Rendering**: simulation of light physics, yielding **photorealism**



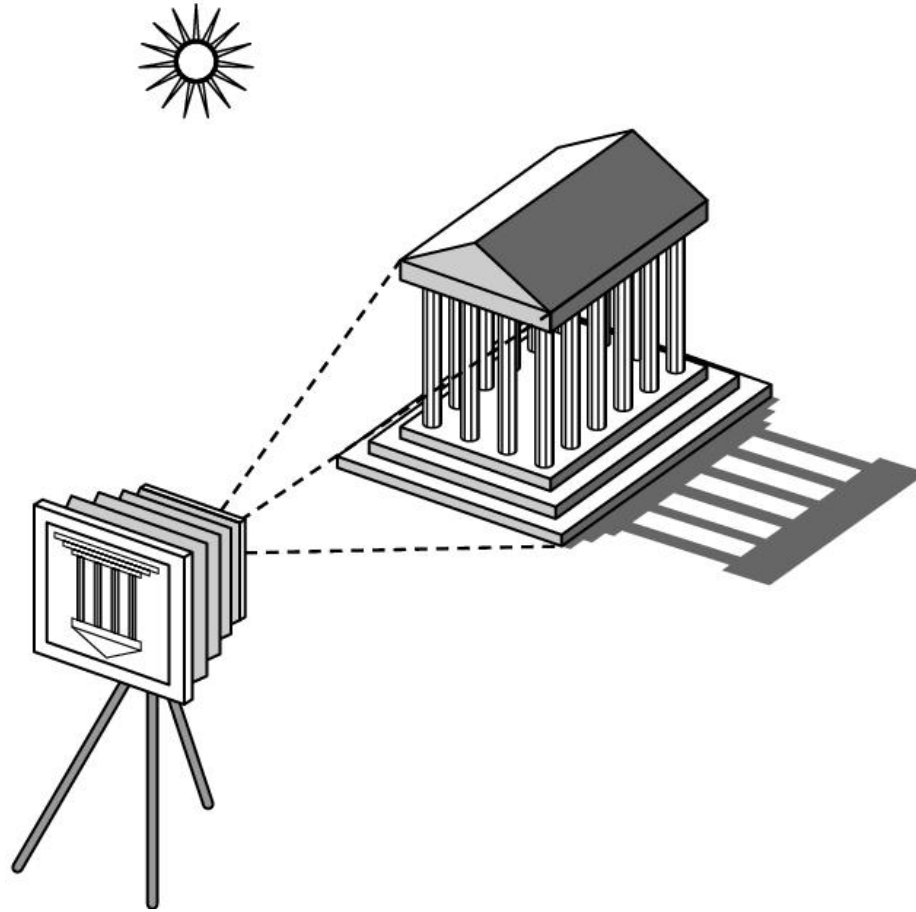
Image Formation

- **In computer graphics, we form images using a model analogous to the physical process**
 - The scene is illuminated by a single light source
 - The scene reflects radiation towards the camera
 - The camera senses it via chemicals on film.



Three Elements of Image Formation

- **Light sources**
- **Objects**
- **Camera**

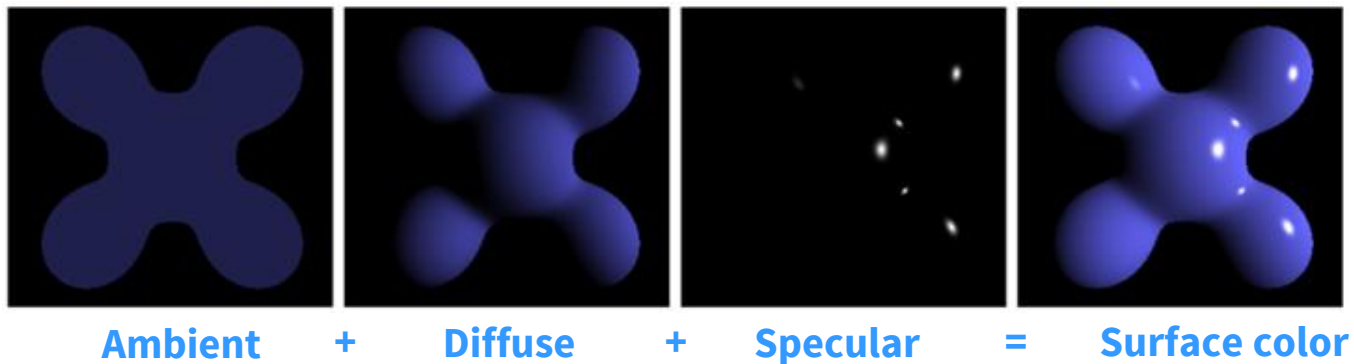


(1) Light Sources

- **Light is the part of the electromagnetic spectrum that causes a reaction in our visual systems**
 - Generally visible spectra are in about wavelengths of 350-750 nm.
 - Long wavelengths appear as reds and short wavelengths as blues.
- **The typical attributes of a light source are:**
 - direction or position (often together)
 - colors (typically, white color is used)

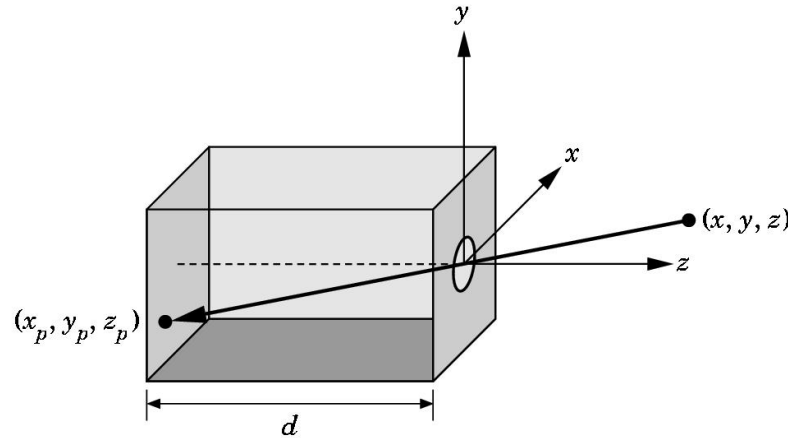
(2) Objects

- **Objects are a set of geometries whose representation is defined mathematically.**
 - As already mentioned, vector graphics representation is used.
 - 3D positions and normal vectors are typically defined.
- **Also, surface properties of the objects are defined to simulate surface interaction with light propagation**
 - Blinn-Phong model uses ambient, diffuse, and specular colors.



(3) Cameras

- **Pinhole camera model, which causes sharp imagery, is common for most of the graphics model.**



- **Typically, the following attributes define a pinhole camera.**
 - 3D transformation of a camera
 - Viewing angle, the aspect ratio of the sensor size, the range of object depths

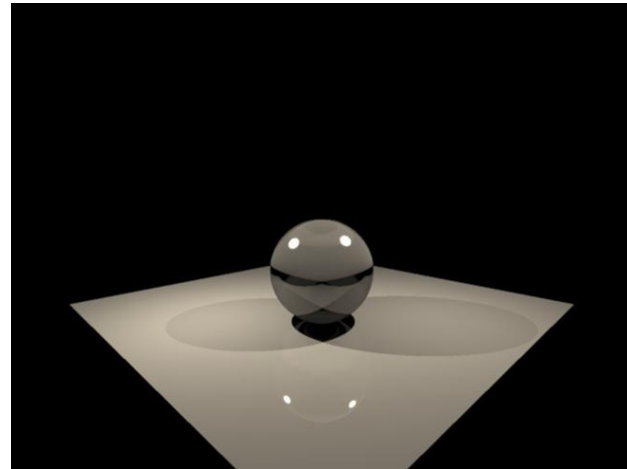
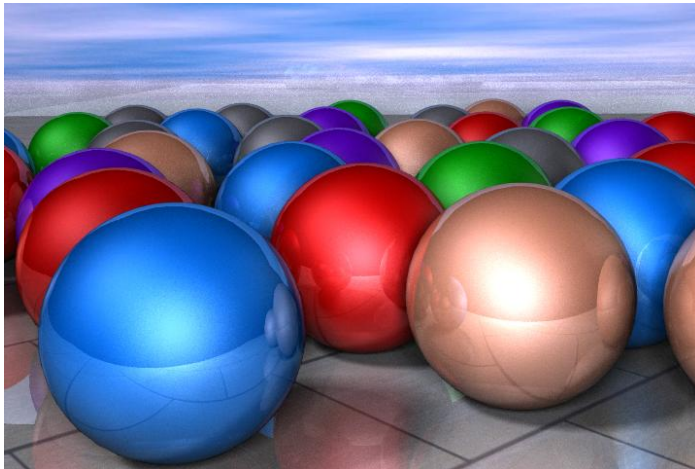
Graphics Systems

Physical Approach

- **Global illumination**

- Captures all the light inter-reflections among surfaces and light sources
- Usually implemented on software
- Very slow and suitable for high-quality film production

- **Typical example: ray tracing**



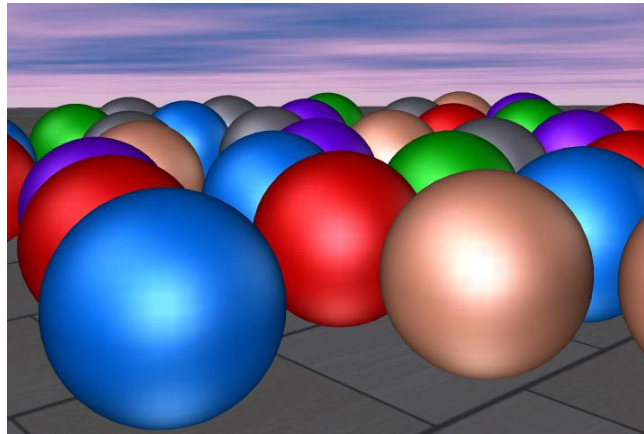
Pipeline Approach

- **Local/direct illumination**

- Captures only direct light-object reflection
- Based on rasterization
- High performance suitable for real-time interactive rendering
- However, quality is degraded with significant approximations.

- **Typical examples**

- OpenGL, on which this course focuses, and DirectX
- Facilitated by special-purpose graphics hardware (GPU)



Pipeline Approach

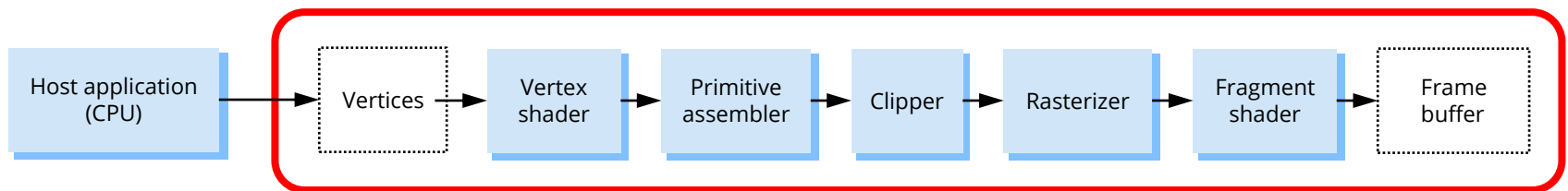
- **Missing visual effects in local illumination model**
 - Inter-object reflections
 - Refractions
 - Shadows
- **However, most of the real-time rendering techniques simulate such effects through approximation.**
 - In most cases, visually plausible but physically degraded.

Raster Pipeline

Raster Pipeline

- **Process objects one at a time in the order they are generated by the application**
 - One unit independently processes a single object but there are more units processing more objects at the same time.
 - Local/direct illumination can be computed without object dependency, and thus, objects are processed independently.

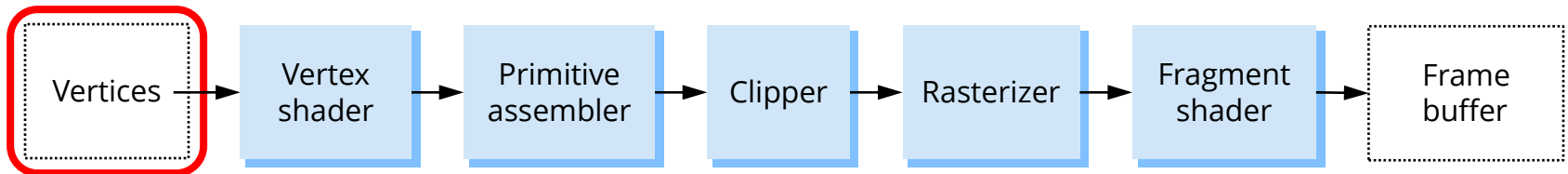
- **Pipeline architecture on graphics hardware**



Graphics Pipeline (GPU)

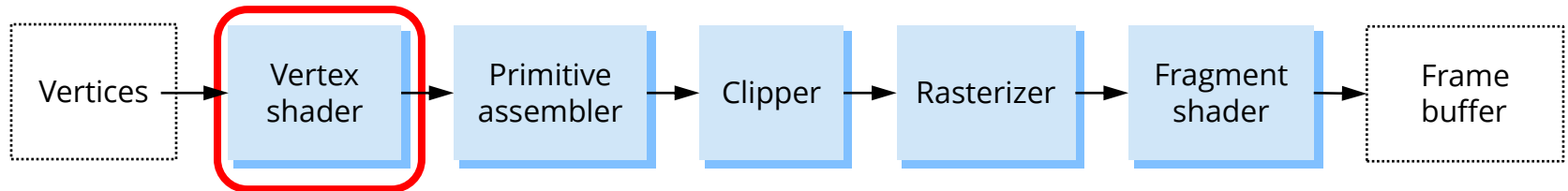
Before Vertex Processing

- **A host application transfers the data in main memory to the GPU memory**
 - Data in GPU memory is only the copy of ones in main memory.
 - We need to maintain the source of GPU memory.
- **Vertex data (buffer) are transferred to GPU.**
 - These do not have to be done for every rendering frame.
 - When there are changes, we update GPU-side data by copying them.



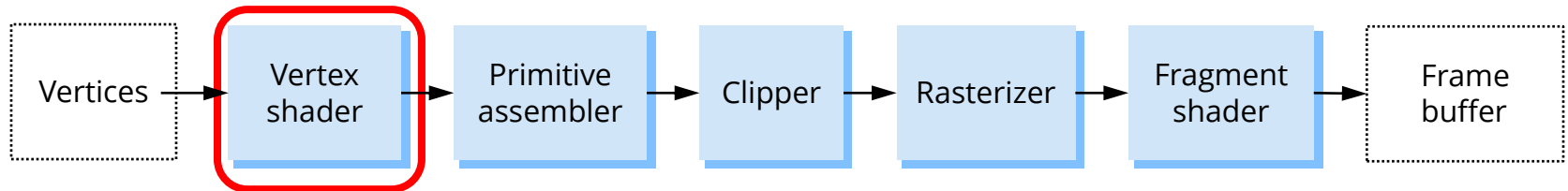
Vertex Processing: 3D Transformation

- **Vertex indicates a single 3D point with its attributes**
 - 3D position, normal vector, and texture coordinate
- **Primary role of vertex processing is positioning a single vertex**
 - Local object coordinates → world object coordinates
 - World object coordinates → camera (eye) coordinates
- **Every change of coordinates is equivalent to a 4×4 matrix transformation**



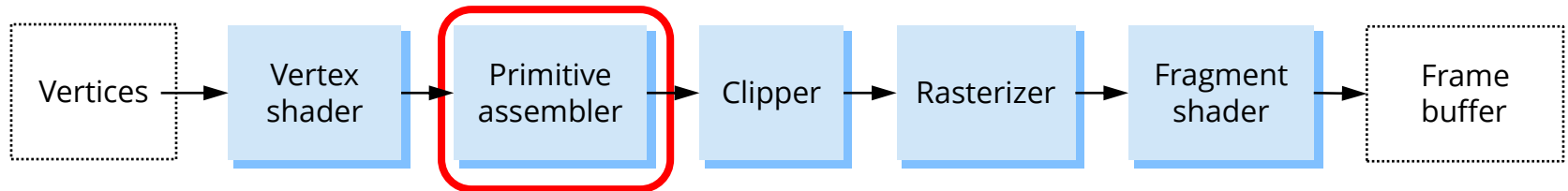
Vertex Processing: Projection

- **Projection is the process that projects 3D camera coordinates to 2D screen (window) coordinates**
 - Perspective projection
 - all projectors meet at the center of projection
 - Parallel projection:
- **The projection is also done with a 4×4 matrix multiplication.**



Primitive Assembly

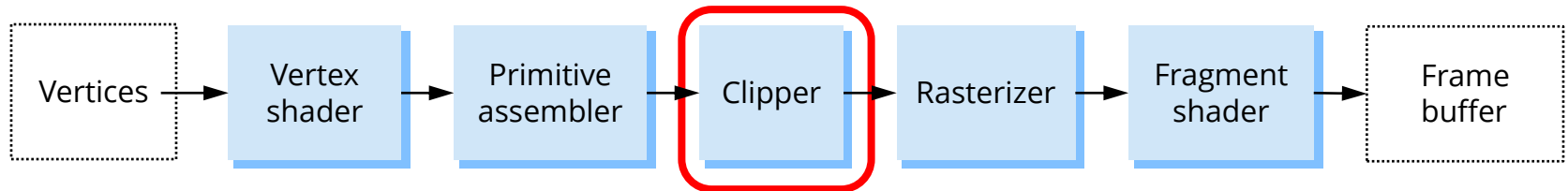
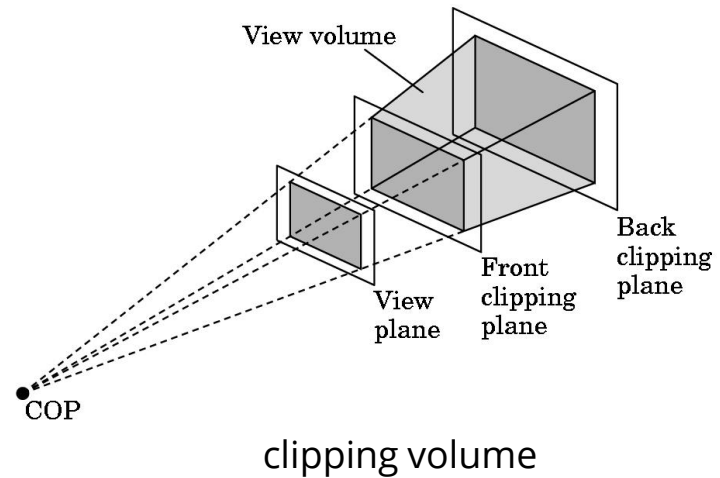
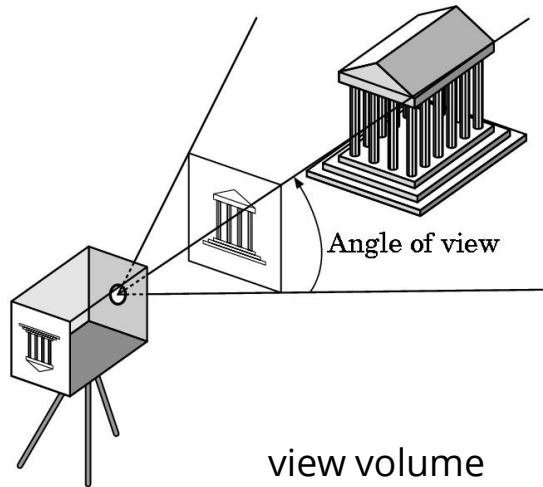
- **Vertices must be collected into geometric objects prior to later steps**
 - Line segments: 2 vertices
 - Triangles: 3 vertices



Clipping

- **Definition:**

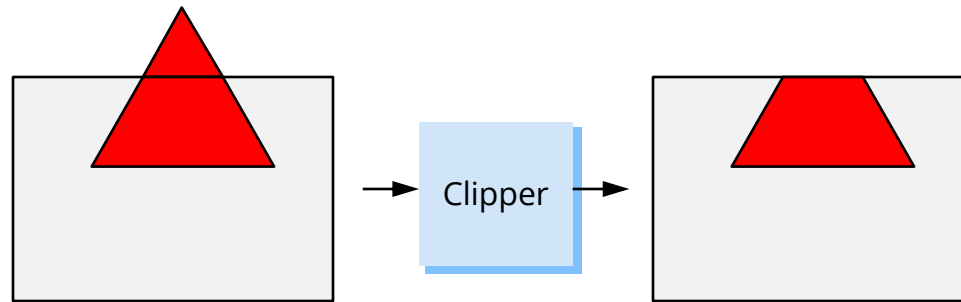
- a process of determining which primitives, or parts of primitives, fit within the clipping volume or view volume.



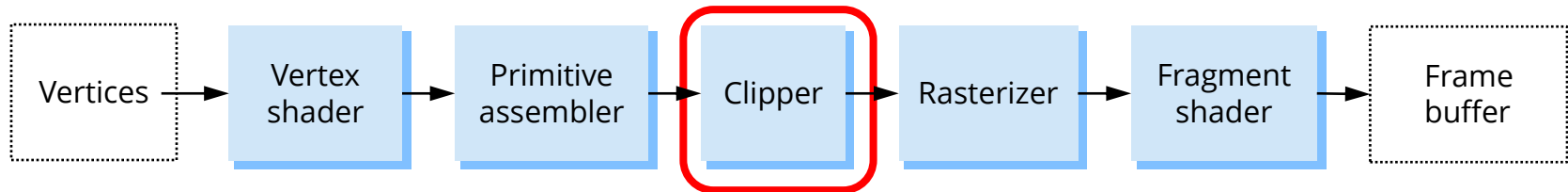
Clipping

- **Triangles partially outside the clipping volume:**

- are subdivided so that the parts within the clipping volume are only processed and the other invisible parts are discarded in the later steps.



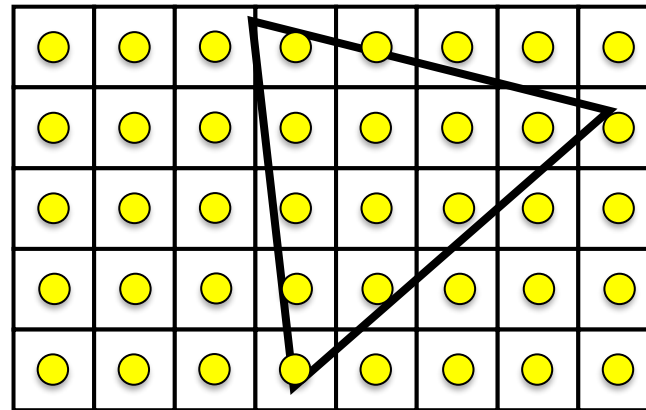
- Hence, invisible triangles completely outside the clipping volume are *clipped out* and no more processed in the later steps.



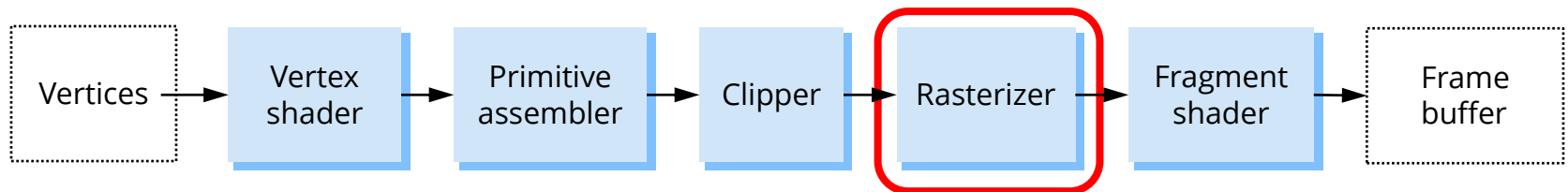
Rasterization

- **Rasterization**

- Conversion of non-clipped objects (in vector graphics formats) to potential pixels (called the *fragments*).
- Produce a set of fragments whose centers lie inside in each triangle.

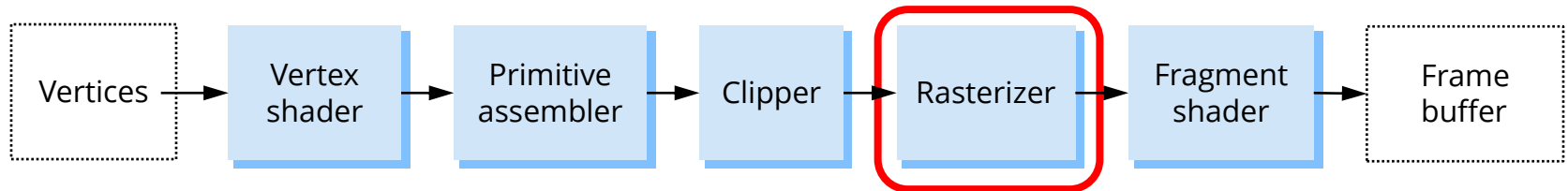
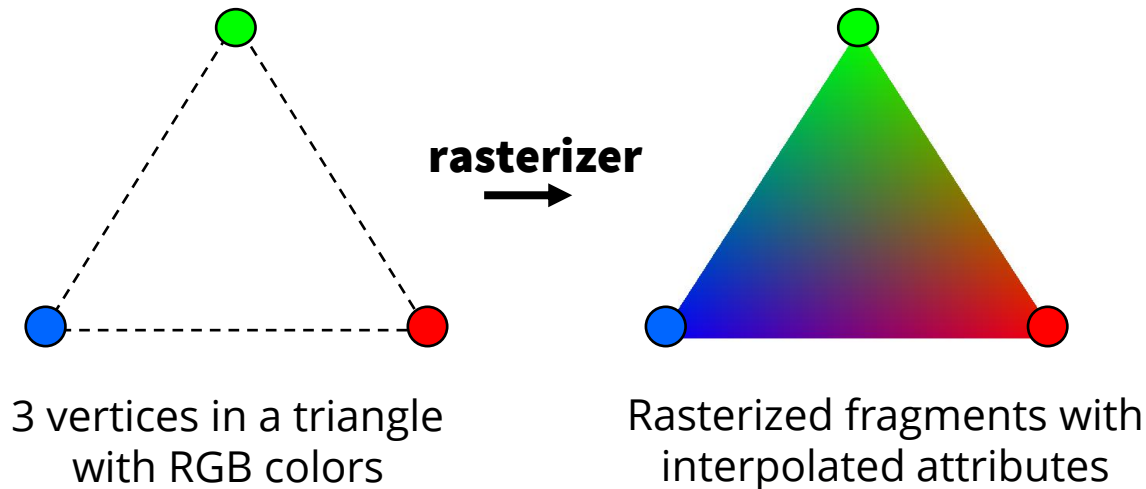


● Sampling point



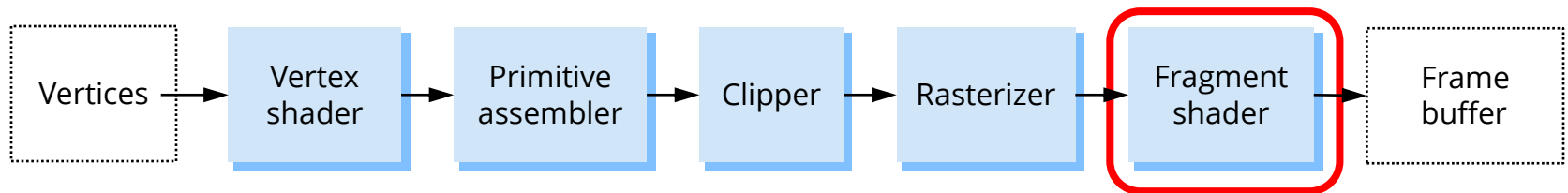
Rasterization

- **Vertex attributes are interpolated over objects by the rasterizer.**
 - 2D screen position, normal vectors, texture coordinates
 - Color and depth attributes



Fragment Processing

- **Fragments are processed to *determine the color* of the corresponding pixel in the frame buffer**
 - Colors can be determined by texture mapping, interpolation of vertex colors, or physically-based shading.
- **Post-fragment operations**
 - The fragment data output is then passed through a sequence of additional post-fragment (per-sample) operations,
 - The post-fragment operations/tests typically include depth test, alpha blending, logical operations, and others.



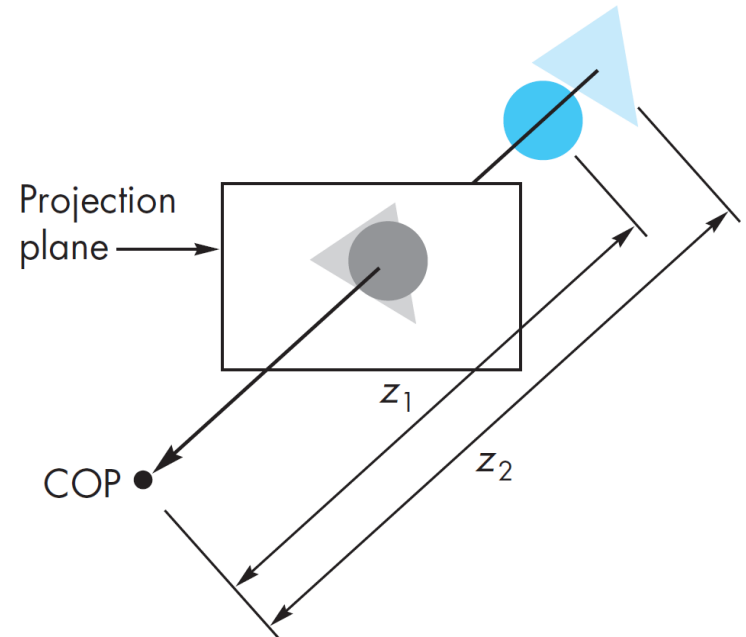
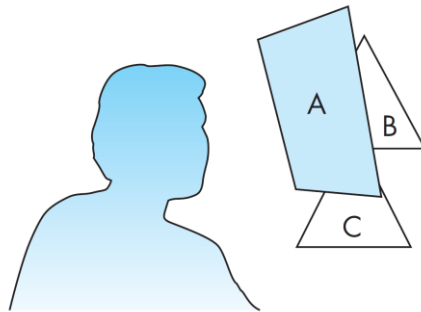
Post-Fragment Operation

- **Depth buffering (depth test, Z-test, or Z-buffering):**

- The frame buffer maintains a depth buffer as well as color buffers to store the depth of the closest fragments at each pixel.
- The depth of a fragment is compared against the depth value in the ZB.
- Only the fragment with a nearer depth value is written to the frame buffer. Otherwise, the fragment is discarded.

- **c.f., Painter's algorithm:**

- One of other hidden surface removal algorithms
- depth-sorted back-to-front rendering



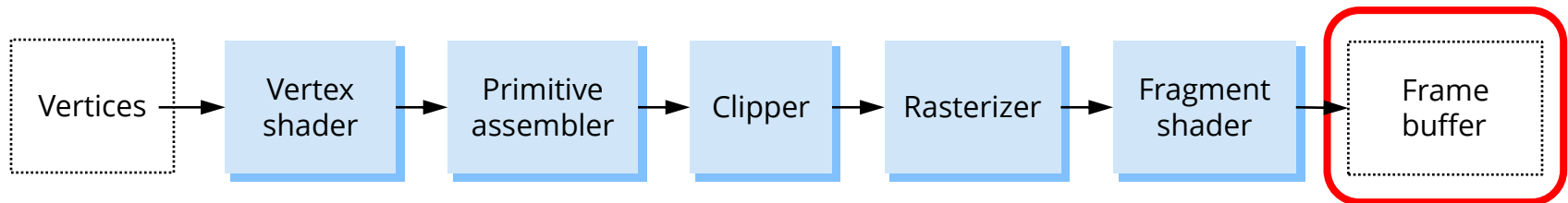
Frame Buffers

- **Pixels in Framebuffers**

- Still alive fragments (now, we call pixels) are transferred to a framebuffer.

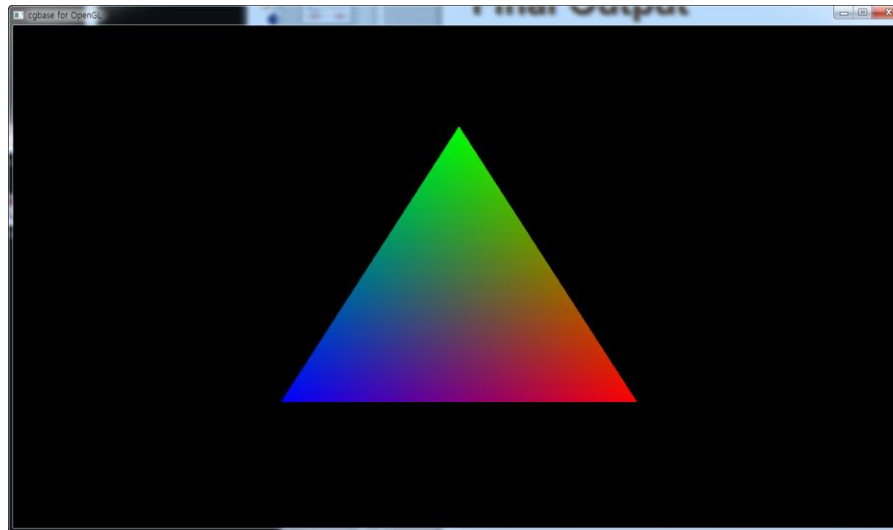
- **Framebuffers**

- 2D memory areas that store fragments/pixels generated via the pipeline.
- Framebuffers are defined by their resolution (width, height) and bit depth (e.g., 8bpp, 16bpp, 32bpp).
- OpenGL maintains front/back (color) buffers (often with left/right for stereoscopic rendering), depth buffer, stencil buffer, and accumulation buffers.



Display

- **The framebuffer transfers its colors to the display devices.**
 - Now we can see an image in the monitor.
 - The transfer is synchronized with the refresh rate of display devices.
 - e.g., monitor refreshes at 60 Hz, and the framebuffer waits for the interval.



Example Data Flow

